Most U.S. and Cuban Protestant pastors left for Miami in the early 1960s. Some Cuban Protestants, however, especially among the Eastern Baptists, saw no conflict between their religion and the Revolution. Reverend Raúl Suárez, a young Baptist minister in eastern Cuba, joined in the defense effort during the exile invasion at the Bay of Pigs in 1961. He went on to take a position as the Vice Rector of the Baptist Seminary in Havana, where he had himself studied, and, in 1971, as Pastor of the Ebenezer Baptist Church – named after the Reverend Martin Luther King, Jr.'s congregation in Atlanta – in the heavily Afro-Cuban Havana neighborhood of Marianao. In the 1980s he became Executive Secretary of the Cuban Ecumenical Council.[40]

In 1984 the Cuban Council of Churches (CCC) invited a delegation of African American religious leaders, including the Reverend Jesse Jackson, to Cuba. Jackson and others met with Fidel Castro – successfully negotiating the release of several dozen political prisoners. In 1987 the CCC, under the leadership of Raúl Suárez, founded the Centro Memorial Martin Luther King, Jr. in Havana.[41]

Cuba's Catholic Church was somewhat isolated from the winds of Liberation Theology that emanated from Rome, and later from meetings of Latin American bishops in Puebla, Mexico and Medellín, Colombia in the late 1960s and early 1970s. But by the 1980s these winds were reaching Cuba, primarily through the Central American revolutions in Nicaragua and El Salvador. In 1986 Brazilian Liberation Theologian Frei Betto published a long interview with Castro, *Fidel and Religion*, in which Castro emphasized the correspondence between Marxist and Christian thought. As in other areas, the Special Period brought some significant openings towards religion, which will be discussed in the next chapters.

Notes

1 de la Fuente, *A Nation for All*, pp. 262, 263.
2 Serviat, "Solutions to the Black Problem," p. 89.
3 Moore, "Black Music in a Raceless Society," p. 8.